58th Morpeth Northumbrian Gathering

Programme 10th–12th April 2026 *(details subject to change)* *Edition 6*

Annual festival of Northumberland's traditional music, dance, dialect, crafts, stories, heritage, family events - + special themed *Vanbrugh Revisited* events for 300th anniversary of Town Hall architect Sir John Vanbrugh.

Beforehand: Fri. 20th March FUNDRAISING CONCERT

Online: Phoenix Folk Pop-Up Ensemble See 10am Sat.

Many free events. Prices: adult /school age. Under 5s free. Sorry no card/phone payments – please bring cash/ cheque. Outdoor events schedule/updates: on Facebook & website. Festival office: Fri/Sat - Town Hall; Sun - Chantry front shop

Friday 10th April:

During today performers will visit local care homes
9.30 - 5.00 **CRAFTS EXHIBITION** + refreshments; crafts competitions (entries received Thur.9th April 5.30pm–7pm), family craft activities, craft displays, stalls, CDs, books, posters, archive photos *Town Hall 50p at door/ accompanied under-12s free*
10.00– 4.00 **OUTDOOR ENTERTAINERS** Punch & Judy, musicians, family history activities *Market Place Free*
10.00 – 4.00 **DANCE WORKSHOPS** 10.00 –11 Historic dances from early 18th century; 11.30–12.30 North'd and Durham Clog (bring flat shoes); 1–2 Maypole 3-4 Long-sword *Town Hall Ballroom £3/£1 at door per session*
11.00-1.00 **HAVE-A-GO NORTHUMBRIAN PIPES drop-in** (beginners; pipes provided) led by Ednie Wilson *Bagp Mus £3/£1*
1.30 – 2.30 **SHANTIES IN THE CHANTRY** Singalong with Ian McKone *Bagpipe Museum £3/£1 at door*
2.00 **OFFICIAL OPENING** of Gathering by the Deputy Mayor of Morpeth, Cllr Wendy Fail *Town Hall Exhibition*
2.15-4.00 **TOWN TREASURES** Tours of Mayor's Parlour, Council Chamber, civic silver, portraits, etc, guided by Deputy Mayor & councillors (tbc) *Town Hall Free*
3.00 – 4.00 **GAELIC SONGS AND DULCIMERS WORK-SHOP** with Linn Phipps and Sandie & Ken Hudson (bring any instrument and/or voice!) *Bagpipe Mus £3/£1 door*
4.30– 5.30 **FAMILY STORIES** Taffy Thomas *Library Free*
4.30 – 5.30 **THE BAILIFFS' BALL** dance event recreating a Morpeth grand assembly of 1726 *Town Hall £3/£1 at door*
7.30 – 9.45 **SIR JOHN'S DELIGHT** Ray Alexander as Sir John Vanbrugh presents his lifestory "A Life of Irony" with musical interludes by Stewart Hardy (fiddle) & ensemble Woolsington Strings *Town Hall Ballroom £9/£5 ticket*
8.00 **SINGAROUND** led by Ed Lawrence and Sam Dodds *Black and Grey Coach House Free (donations welcome)*
8.00 **MUSICIANS' SESSION** *Tap & Spile (donations)*

Saturday 11th April: *9-4 **FREE** Park&Ride at County Hall*

9.30 – 4.30 **CRAFTS EXHIBITION** as Friday *Town Hall*
9.45–10.30 **FAMILY STORIES** Taffy Thomas *Library Free*
10.00– 4.00 **OUTDOOR ENTERTAINERS** Punch & Judy, music, Ellington Colliery Band, local morris, clog & rapper teams *Market Place, Park, Bakehouse Millennium Green*
10.00 – 4.00 **MORPETH CASTLE OPEN DAY** history, stories & music. Arranged with Landmark Trust *Free*
10.00 – 10.45 **MEET THE NORTHUMBRIAN PIPERS** Drop-in to hear the small pipes *Bagpipe Museum Free*
10.00 – 10.50 **POP-UP FOLK ENSEMBLE** Prepare for tonight's concert (tunes: http://phoenixfolk.co.uk/morpeth to download, or just turn up) *St Robt's Ch Hall (donations)*
10.15 **RING O' BELLS**; Clock Tower tours from 12 approx
11.00 **PROCESSION** Gadgy's Welcome at Market Place *(road closed 10.30-11.45am from Chantry to Manchester St., traffic diverted Dark Lane/Stanley Terrace/Wellway).*
12.00– 4.00 **STORYTELLER'S GARDEN** Taffy Thomas's stories, dancers, music *Old Bakehouse Yard Millen Green*
12.00 **MUSICIANS' SESSION** *Tap & Spile (donations)*
12.00 - 3.00 **SINGAROUND** led by Ed Lawrence and Sam Dodds *Joiners Arms (free – donations welcome)*

Competitions: All-venue passport ticket for Saturday comp'n entrants/audience including craft exhibition £3.00/£1.00. Doors open 30 mins before times below to allow entrants to register.

12.00 **CLOG DANCE** solos & groups **competitions relaunch** with demo by Two Step *Town Hall Ballroom*

1.45 **SPEAKING & WRITING**: dialect, stories, results of pre-judged written items-deadline 7 Mar. **featuring launch of Alex Swailes Memorial young performer award** *St Robt's Ch.Hall*

1.45 **NORTHUMBRIAN PIPES** & LOWLAND/ BORDER /HALF-LONG PIPES *Chantry Bagpipe Museum*

2.00 **BANDS, ACCORDIONS, FIDDLES, OTHER INSTRUMENTS, DUETS** *St. George's UR Church*

3.30 **SINGING**: solos and groups *Town Hall Ballroom*

1.30 – 2.30 **FAMILY SHOW** Storytellers' Street Band, Jim Eldon + Silly Songs *St James Centre £3/£1 requested at door*
4.00 - 5.15 **WOR HOOSE** Heather Laurence introduces her dialect play on NE life *St Robt's Ch Hall £3/£1 at door*
4.00 - 6.00 **SLOW & STEADY** session led by BITS NE for beginners+intermediates *The Wansbeck, Kirkhill (donations)*
4.00 – 5.15 **MORPETH'S MERRIE MUSICKES** Early 18th century music from countryside and theatre (Vanbrugh's vintage) with Bennett Hogg, Matt Seattle and friends on strings and Border pipes *Bagpipe Museum £6/£2 ticket*
6.30– 8.30 **WINNERS' CONCERT** 2025 winners, Pop-up ensemble, guest band Ape House *Town Hall £9/£5 ticket)*
8.00 **MUSICIANS' SESSION** *Tap & Spile (donations)*
8.00 **NORTHUMBRIAN & BORDER PIPING SESSION** *Conservative Club front lounge Free (donations)*
8.30 – 11.00 **BARN DANCE** Blue Hat Ceilidh Band, guest spots. Bring own drinks *Town Hall Corn Exch £9/£5 ticket*

Sunday 12th April: Sorry, no Sunday Crafts Exhibition this year

10.00–4.00 **MORPETH CASTLE OPEN DAY** as Saturday
10.30 – 2.30 **OUTDOOR ENTERTAINERS** Duke's Dandy Clog, maypole dancing, etc *Market Place and Park*
10.30 – 12.00 **MORPETH HERITAGE WALK** from Market Place (must book in advance 01670 513308) *Donations*
10.30 – 11.30 **CHURCH SERVICE** Dialect hymns & items from Gathering performers *St George's URC (new venue)*
11.00 –12.00 **GAELIC PIPING SONGS WORKSHOP** with Linn Phipps *Chantry Bagpipe Museum £3/£1 at door*
12.00 - 3.00 **MUSICIANS' SESSION** *Tap & Spile Free*
12.30 – 1.30 **THE STORYTELLER'S ALMANAC** Mossy Christian & Taffy Thomas MBE with Tales & Tunes of Folk Calendar Customs *St James Cent £5/£1 requested at door*
12.30 – 1.30 **GALLIARD CONSORT** Open rehearsal of recorder music from Vanbrugh's time *Bagpipe Mus £3/£1*
2.00 – 3.00 **DROP-IN DULCIMER WORKSHOP** Nonsuch Dulcimer Club 'Come and Try' session on hammered and mountain dulcimers *Bagpipe Museum £3/£1 at door*
2.15 – 3.30 **FAMILY CEILIDH** Little Big Blue Ceilidh Band plus storytelling *St James Centre £4/£1 requested at door*